



Representatives of France's "Third Estate"—the people—swore the "Tennis Court Oath" not to separate until they had established a constitution in France.

“LIBERTÉ, ÉGALITÉ, FRATERNITÉ!”

“Liberty, Equality, Fraternity!”
Rallying cry of the French Revolution, 1789

BY 1789, FRANCE'S LOUIS XVI was facing multiple crises: he was bankrupt from endless warfare, there was popular unrest, and the failure of the 1788 grain crop meant riots over bread. The decision was made to summon the **Estates-General**, France's representative assembly. It had not met since 1614, so between January and April elections were held to select deputies. The Estates-General was composed of three “estates” or orders: the



The three estates

These figures (from left to right) symbolize each of the estates representing France: the nobility, the people, and the clergy.

First Estate (the clergy); the Second Estate (the nobility); and the **Third Estate—the people**. The assembly met at Versailles on May 5. The immediate issue was how much voting power to give the Third Estate; the First and Second Estates wanted voting to be by estate rather than a vote per head, so that they would not be outnumbered by the public's representatives. By June 17 the

frustrated Third Estate declared itself a **National Assembly** and decided to proceed without the nobles and clergy. This prompted officials to lock them out of their usual meeting place, so they occupied Louis XVI's indoor tennis court and swore an oath on June 20 to remain united until they produced a constitution for France, a pledge that became known as the **Tennis Court Oath**. All but one of the 577 deputies signed; Joseph Martin Dauch from Castelnaudary refused to endorse it because it was not sanctioned by the king.

Louis XVI felt he had no option but to give in to the demands of the Third Estate and urged the nobility and clergy to join what, by July 9, was named the **National Constituent Assembly** (though it continued to be called the National Assembly).

A few days later, Paris was awash with rumors, including that troops were on their way into the city to disperse the National Assembly. In response, on the afternoon of July 14, some 600 people armed with weapons seized from the Hôtel des Invalides attacked the **Bastille**, a medieval fortress used as a prison. The Bastille held only seven prisoners at the time of the attack, but it symbolized the despotism of the monarchy and contained ammunition the people wanted to seize. The uprising, in which a whole garrison and 98 attackers died, became a defining moment of the **French Revolution**, which was now underway.

600 THE NUMBER OF PEOPLE WHO STORMED THE BASTILLE

Storming of the Bastille

The crowd of around 600 people that gathered outside the prison calling for its surrender was peaceful at first, but violence soon broke out.

During late July and early August, rumors spread throughout the French countryside, which was already in a state of unrest due to grain shortages. There were fears of bandits sweeping the land and stories of crops being burned. During this period, known as the **Great Fear**, panic set in among many peasants, who armed themselves and attacked nobles and their châteaux.

By August 4, the National Constituent Assembly sought to control the situation and so decreed the **abolition of feudalism** and the tithe. This was

followed on August 26 by the publication of the **Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen**, which proclaimed that “men are **born free** and **remain free** and equal in rights” and that “the source of all sovereignty lies essentially in the Nation.”

Throughout this period of upheaval, uncensored newspapers reported events and **political clubs** formed where people could voice their opinions. Despite the onslaught of new freedoms and monumental social reform, the Revolution was in its infancy—France's future was far from clear.



January French Estates-General is summoned

February 4 George Washington (1737–99) elected first president of the US (to 1797)

The autobiography of Olaudah Equiano, a slave captured as a child in Africa, is published

April 28 Mutiny on the HMS Bounty, led by English sailor Fletcher Christian

April 7 Selim III (1761–1808) becomes Ottoman sultan

June–July Spain captures three English ships in Pacific Northwest, triggering **Nootka Sound** crisis

June 3 Alexander MacKenzie sets out to explore the Mackenzie River by canoe from central Canada to the Arctic Ocean

July 14 Storming of the Bastille

June 20 Tennis Court Oath taken

August 26 Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen is published

September 22 Russians crush Turks in Battle of Rymnik during Russo-Turkish war

September 25 US Congress proposes Bill of Rights, the first 10 amendments to the US Constitution